

Chapter 1: "Goodbye, Daddy"

This chapter introduces young Ben Carson and the emotional impact of his parents' divorce. His father leaves the family, leading Ben to experience feelings of confusion and heartbreak. Raised by his mother, Sonya Carson, the chapter sets the foundation for Ben's challenging childhood.

Chapter 2: "Carrying the Load"

Sonya Carson works multiple jobs to support her two sons. Despite her struggles, she motivates Ben and his brother Curtis to value education. She refuses to allow Curtis to be placed in vocational courses, insisting he aim for college. Her persistence defines her parenting approach, instilling a strong work ethic in her children.

Chapter 3: "Eight Years Old"

The family moves to Boston after financial difficulties. The conditions in Boston are tough, with Ben encountering rats and living in poverty. Despite the hardship, Ben's mother continues to inspire him with her belief in his potential and constant encouragement.

Chapter 4: "Two Positives"

Ben's academic performance starts to improve when he gets glasses and begins to see the chalkboard clearly. This leads to slight improvements in school, but his mother is not satisfied with just passing grades. She implements strict study rules, limiting TV time and encouraging him to read two books a week.

Chapter 5: "A Boy's Big Problem"

Ben struggles with peer pressure and fitting in at his new school in Detroit. His clothes and background make him a target for teasing, and he faces challenges with his self-esteem. However, his mother's belief in him continues to push him toward academic success.

Chapter 6: "A Terrible Temper"

Ben's violent temper is highlighted, culminating in a near-stabbing incident with a friend. He realizes the dangerous path his anger is leading him down and turns to God, asking for help in controlling his temper. This moment becomes a turning point in his life.

Chapter 7: "ROTC Triumph"

Ben excels in the ROTC program, where he gains leadership skills and confidence. He eventually becomes the city's top ROTC officer, a position that boosts his self-esteem and demonstrates his capacity for hard work and discipline.

Chapter 8: "College Choices"

This chapter discusses Ben's academic achievements and college opportunities. He earns a scholarship to Yale University and begins his journey in higher education. The financial struggles of his college years are covered, as well as his determination to succeed.

Chapter 9: "Changing the Rules"

Ben faces new challenges at Yale, where the academic pressure is immense. He adapts to college life, learning to navigate his new environment and work harder to maintain his grades. His adaptability and resilience are emphasized.

Chapter 10: "A Serious Step"

Ben decides to pursue a career in neurosurgery during medical school. This chapter details his growing passion for medicine, particularly brain surgery, and his determination to follow this challenging path.

Chapter 11: "Another Step Forward"

In medical school at the University of Michigan, Ben hones his skills as a future neurosurgeon. His faith and work ethic continue to guide him as he faces difficult tests and demanding coursework.

Chapter 12: "Coming Into My Own"

Ben's residency at Johns Hopkins marks a significant milestone in his career. He begins to gain recognition for his talent and hard work, setting the stage for his later groundbreaking surgeries.

Chapter 13: "A Special Year"

This chapter covers a year of significant growth in Ben's career. He gains confidence in his surgical abilities and tackles increasingly complex cases. His reputation in neurosurgery begins to spread.

Chapter 14: "A Girl Named Maranda"

Ben performs a successful hemispherectomy on a young girl named Maranda, who suffers from severe seizures. This surgery marks a major achievement in Ben's career and showcases his ability to innovate in the field of neurosurgery.

Chapter 15: "Heartbreak"

This chapter deals with the emotional challenges of being a surgeon, particularly when patients don't survive. Ben experiences the heartbreak of losing patients despite his best efforts, which shapes his emotional resilience.

Chapter 16: "Little Beth"

Ben operates on a girl named Beth, another patient with severe neurological issues. Her case highlights the delicate balance between success and failure in neurosurgery, as Ben continues to push boundaries in his field.

Chapter 17: "Three Special Children"

Ben performs complex surgeries on three children, each presenting unique medical challenges. These cases further establish him as a leader in pediatric neurosurgery.

Chapter 18: "Craig and Susan"

This chapter focuses on another set of twins, Craig and Susan, who require Ben's surgical expertise. The chapter details the intricate planning and teamwork required for such high-risk surgeries.

Chapter 19: "Separating the Twins"

This chapter covers Ben's most famous case: the separation of conjoined twins, Patrick and Benjamin Binder. The surgery was one of the most challenging in medical history, requiring a 70-member team and 22 hours of surgery. It was a landmark achievement that made Ben Carson internationally famous.

Chapter 20: "The Rest of Their Story"

Ben reflects on the aftermath of the twins' surgery and the long-term outcomes of his patients. He emphasizes the collaborative nature of such complex surgeries and the emotional toll they take on the medical team.

Chapter 21: "Family Affairs"

This chapter highlights Ben's personal life, focusing on his marriage to Candy and the birth of their children. Ben reflects on the importance of balancing his demanding career with family life.

Chapter 22: "Think Big"

The final chapter presents Ben's philosophy on life and success, summarized in the acronym THINK BIG. He encourages others to strive for greatness by focusing on Talent, Honesty, Insight, Niceness, Knowledge, Books, In-depth learning, and God. This chapter serves as an inspirational message to young readers, particularly those facing adversity.